"COMBATING TERRORISM: Increased Oversight and Accountability Over Pakistan Reimbursement Claims for Coalition Support Funds Needed,"

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE COMMENTS ON
THE DRAFT REPORT BY GAO ON COALITION SUPPORT FUNDS

The Department of Defense (DoD) appreciates the opportunity to comment on this draft report. DoD welcomes periodic reviews on the administration of critical DoD programs like Coalition Support Funds (CSF) and looks forward to recommendations to enhance effectiveness and oversight. In the case of this investigation, however, DoD believes the draft of the final report fails to give sufficient weight to three key areas:

- The context in which CSF evolved, the significant contribution to the Global War on Terror (GWoT) that Pakistan has made and that CSF enabled, and the required flexibility in guidance and processes for contingency environments.
- The fact that the Department has consistently adhered to the letter and spirit of the law while continuously providing oversight and analysis of submissions.
- That Pakistan and several other recipients of reimbursements under the CSF authority are sovereign countries that may not meet U.S.-comparable standards of accounting and administration.

CSF Context

During the buildup and initial phases of Operation Enduring Freedom (OEF), Pakistan allowed the U.S. nearly unlimited use of its airspace, made available four of its air bases and one seaport for staging and onward movement of deploying coalition forces, provided jet fuel and other utilities at these locations, and deployed substantial ground forces to provide force protection. In December 2001, at U.S. request, the Pakistan Army deployed major ground forces for the first time in its history into the largely ungoverned Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) to attempt to capture remnants of Al Qaeda and Afghan Taliban forces fleeing into Pakistan from the Tora Bora area of Afghanistan.

As of October 2007, approximately 40 percent of fuel (roughly 120,000 gallons per day) and 84 percent of all containerized cargo for delivery to Coalition forces operating in Afghanistan passed through Pakistan. Pakistan's cooperation in facilitating this support is a critical component of the Coalition's ability to operate in Afghanistan.

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